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The decade stands out as one of the most ambitious phases of socio-economic lawmaking since Independence. It was an era when the Indian State sought to redefine its relationship with citizens by moving decisively from welfare as discretion to welfare as entitlement. These laws did not merely redistribute resources. They reshaped expectations, redefined rights and altered the grammar of governance itself.

The turning point came in 2005 with the Right to Information (RTI) Act. For the first time, access to government records was no longer a privilege mediated by power, but a statutory right vested in the citizen. RTI cracked open the opaque architecture of the Indian State and forced officials, politicians and institutions into an unprecedented culture of explanation. It also became the backbone of civil society activism and investigative journalism, exposing corruption and inefficiency across sectors. RTI did not clean up the system, but it fundamentally altered the balance of power between the State and the citizen.

In the same year, Parliament enacted the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act. By making employment a legal right for rural households, the law attempted to provide income security at the bottom of the pyramid while creating durable rural assets.



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

CITIZEN WATCH
Social activist Aruna Roy demanding public audit and transparency in MGNREGA works in Jaipur, Dec. 2009

The Great Leap Backward
May 15, 2006

❝The Congress believes it can alter its state of irrelevance in over 200 Parliamentary seats by wooing back the Dalits and, perhaps, get a share of the OBCs, too. Witness the programmes it is pushing through. There's a certain gameplan that is undeniable. The National Rural Employment Guarantee Bill, the Forests Land for Tribals Bill, the newly-mooted quota in central universities and now, the proposition of jobs for Dalits in the private sector are all aimed at inclusive growth. They are also about ramping up vote share to take the Congress closer to a single party majority.❞

